



Billiard Basics: Shoot Pool like a Pro



BILLIARDS—a category of table games involving cues and balls—came about in the 15th century, with great popularity in Northern Europe and France. Everyone from peasants to kings played the sport. Since then, billiards have evolved so much that versions today hardly resemble the original. In general, three main gameplays now exist:

- ◇ Carom, the simplest of the set, does not use pockets because there are only three balls in play—an object, a cue and an opponent;
- ◇ Pool requires six deep pockets and 15 balls, wracked tightly into a triangular formation (nine for the variant 9Ball);
- ◇ Snooker involves six pockets and 22 balls, configured like pool but on a bigger table and with balls outside of the triangular formation.

Players use the same striking technique for all gameplays, meaning common shots exist across all three. For this reason, our guide focuses on shooting instead of rules or strategies. Appropriately, we have categorized all shots into three sections, each sequenced according to difficulty.

Next to each shot's name, you will find statistics (%)—how often the object ball goes into the pocket. You may find these inaccurate at first due to variables like levelness, grip, finger support, power, resistance (i.e. glove versus bare fingers) and chalkiness. With a bit of practice, though, these things will sort themselves out.



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Point of Impact

In billiards, the cue ball is most important; it is the only ball you strike directly with the cue. When shooting, always follow through, aiming at its middle and ending with the tip of your cue one to two inches in front of the ball's starting position. Careful to only tap the ball. Do not guide or push it. Strike slowly at first to familiarize yourself with the movement and table (figure 1).

Once comfortable shooting at the middle, experiment with the eight points of impact on a cue ball (figure 2). Aim at the different quadrants to spin forward, backwards or to the side. The shots in this section will develop this technique. Bear in mind, however, that jump shots are illegal in most pool halls and competitions.

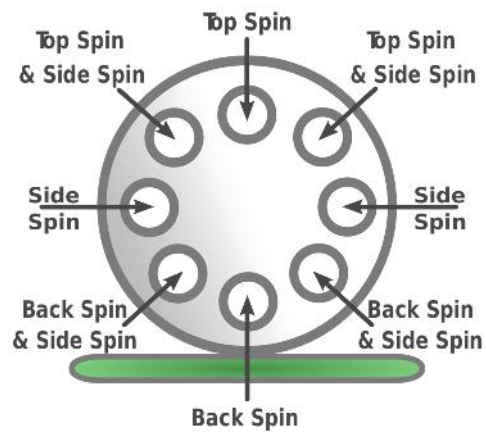
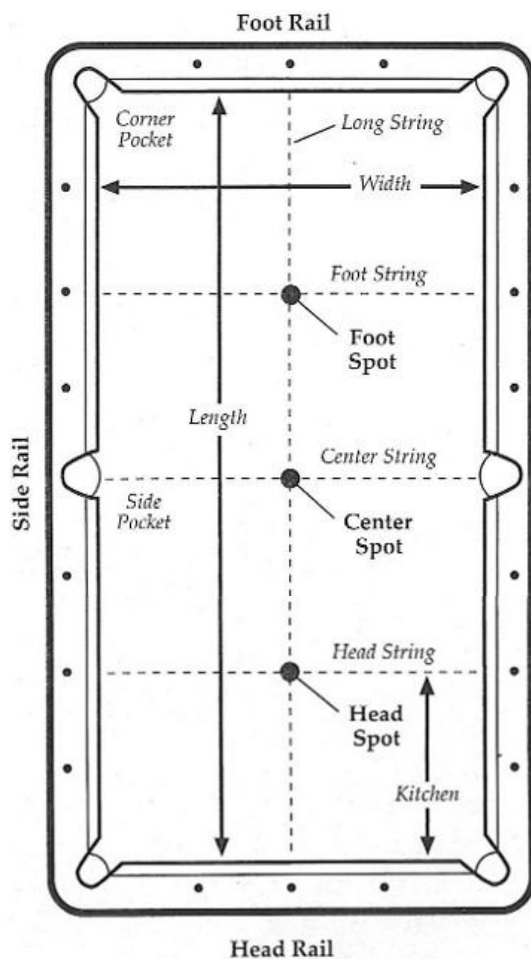


Figure 1 (left): Billiard table diagram.

Figure 2 (above): Points of impact and points of direction.



The Draw Shot (60% to 80%)

The draw shot is perhaps the most useful to learn and the easiest to master. Strike the cue ball right below the centre for backspin, causing the ball to retreat after colliding with the object. How much backspin produced depends on the power you put into it.

The goal of the draw shot is to pocket object balls without *sewering*—accidentally sinking the cue ball. Additionally, it allows you to setup subsequent shots by choosing the cue ball's resting place after execution.

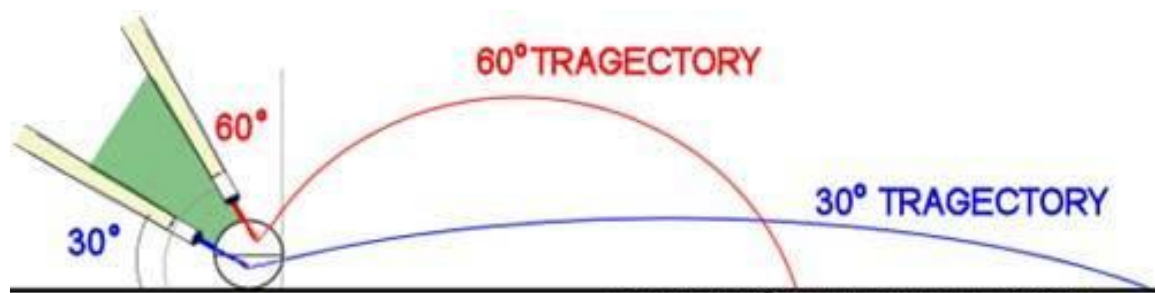


Figure 3: Illustration of angles for performing jump shots.

The Jump Shot (5% to 25%)

Although illegal, you can jump balls to impress friends and show off your skills. Besides looking cool, they are also practical: use this shot to hop over obstacles and avoid scratching—when the cue ball fails to contact an object.

To successfully jump a ball, strike down at 30 or 60 degrees, measured from the centre of the cue ball; anything below will result in scooping (figure 3). Jump shots risk damage to the table and injury to other players when done with excessive force, so proceed cautiously if permitted in the hall or home. And keep all balls off the floor!

Off the Rail

By bouncing the cue ball off of the *rail*, sometimes referred to as the *cushion*, you create detours when all straight paths are blocked. Multi-rebound shots—those that hit the rails more than once—are tough to predict because the angle changes for each successive bounce. Should you miss the mark on the first rail, all follow up hits exaggerate this miscalculation. For better accuracy, refer to the dots on the side of your table (figure 4).

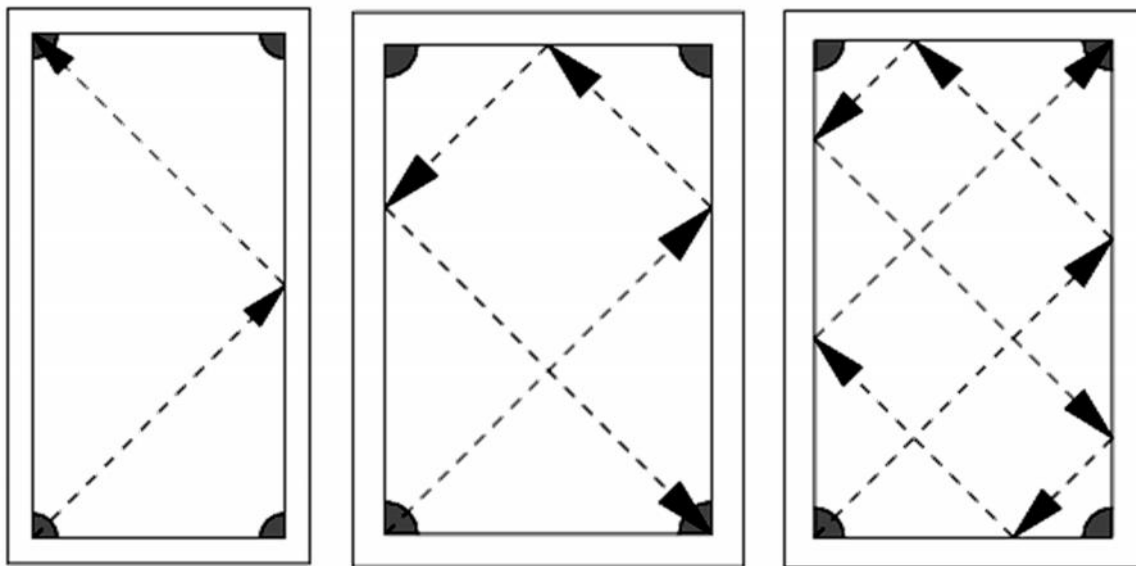


Figure 4: Table grids based on the dots or inlays found on the rails.

The Kick Shot (35% to 55%)

To perform a kick shot, use the rail to deflect your cue ball into the appropriate object ball. This is trickier than it sounds for two reasons: (1) the ball needs to hit the right spot in order to then meet the target straight on or at the desired angle; (2) the cue ball must bounce safely off the rail, avoiding pockets and opponent balls along the way.

Tip! Map out your shots by imagining a ghost ball, one that represents your cue ball leading up to its point of impact. This method allows you to mentally plot your shot in stages, working through complex setups from a variety of perspectives.



The Bank Shot (20% to 40%)

A game rarely passes without one bank shot. Similar to a kick shot, perform this by using the rail to rebound object balls towards a pocket. Understandably, bank shots save the game when your cue ball has a clear path but the space between the pocket and object is obstructed.

You may find bank shots easiest when the object ball sits considerably far from the pocket. Regardless of distance, use the inlays on the rail to calculate your angles. To do so, envision a straight line towards the nearest dot and then form a reflection of that line from where the ball will make contact. Move these imaginary lines along the rail until aligned with a pocket.

There are two variants of the basic bank shot:

- Multi-Rail Bank Shot (30% to 50%)—bounce the object ball off the rail as many times as it takes to find a safe route to the pocket;
- Spin-Bank Shot (15% to 35%)—spin the cue ball to make the rebound angle wider or narrower.

Multi-rail and spin-bank shots are difficult to execute even for professionals, a reason why they have such low percentages. Although they come in handy, explore the table for alternatives, using these tricks only as a last resort.

Multiple Object Hits

Just as rails help you to avoid obstacles, non-object balls can change the path of a cue or object ball too. Since multiple balls are involved, though, you must factor in ricochet and collateral-ball placement—where the cue ball will rest and where all non-object balls will go afterwards. For instance, striking with only half of the cue ball forces the receiving ball to veer 30 degrees (figure 5). Consequently, where might both balls go next? Does this set the next player up or disadvantage you later in the game?



The Carom Shot (50% to 70%)

Carom shots knock object balls off of non-object balls to sink otherwise impossible arrangements. Use this when one or more balls partially obstruct your path towards the pocket. The multiple collisions make this shot somewhat unpredictable, especially because the second hit absorbs more impact than the first, thus reducing the momentum and lessening the angle. For this reason, do not attempt carom shots of three balls or more.

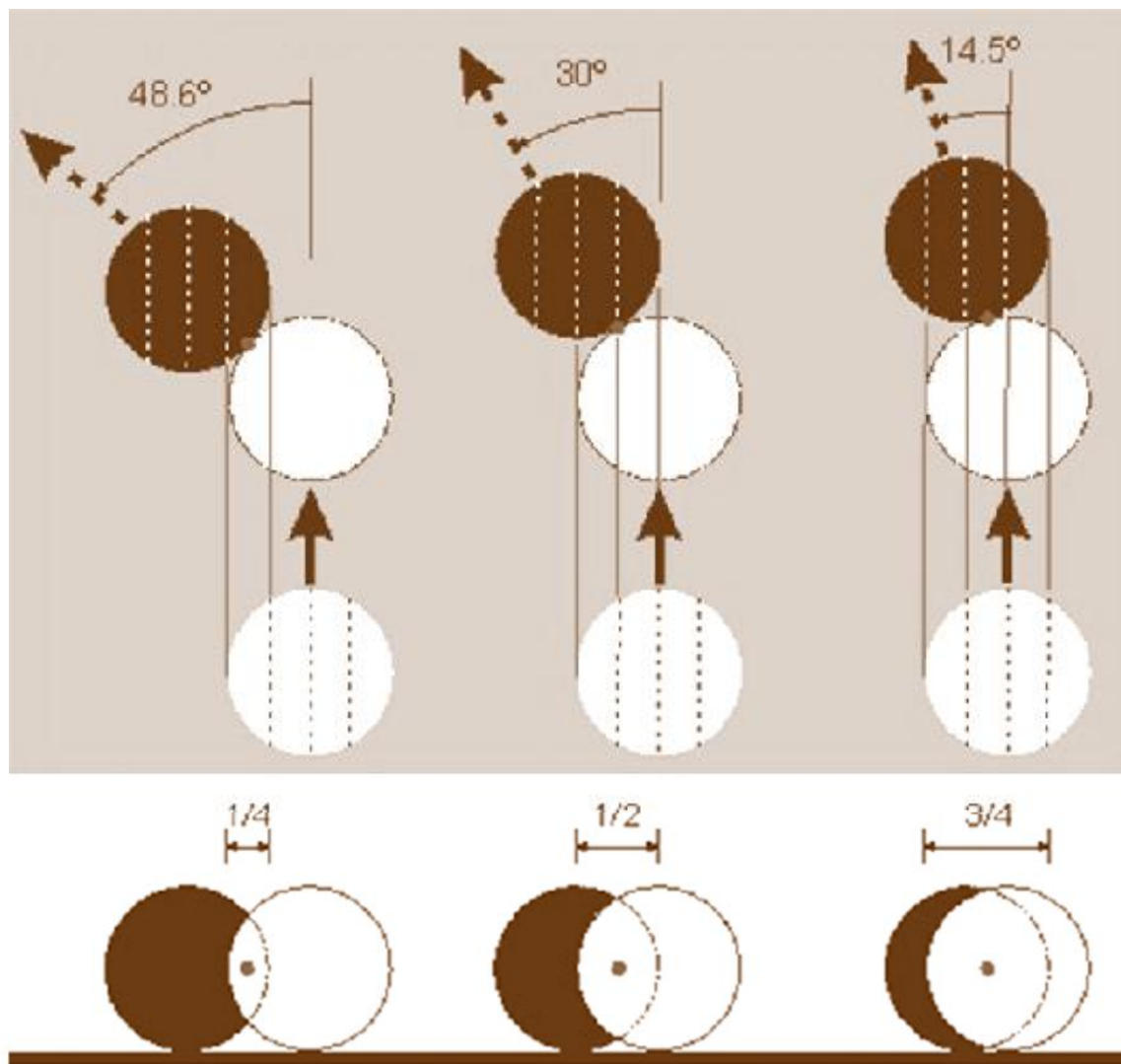


Figure 5: Angles created with ball-to-ball contact.



The carom shot works best when the object ball lies near the pocket; the difficulty of the shot depends largely on distance and speed. Perform these shots slowly.

The Combination Shot (60% to 80%)

Combination shots also involve one or more non-object balls. The difference, however, is that combination shots use a series of non-object balls to hit the intended ball, thus the cue ball never touches its target (figure 6).

Each progressive hit in a combination shot creates its own angle, so the slightest miscalculation can have a chain-like effect. Keep in mind that you cannot shoot at an opponent's ball (i.e. stripes versus solids), so this shot may not always be available. When done correctly, though, it saves you from scratching or gives you the opportunity to sink multiple objects.

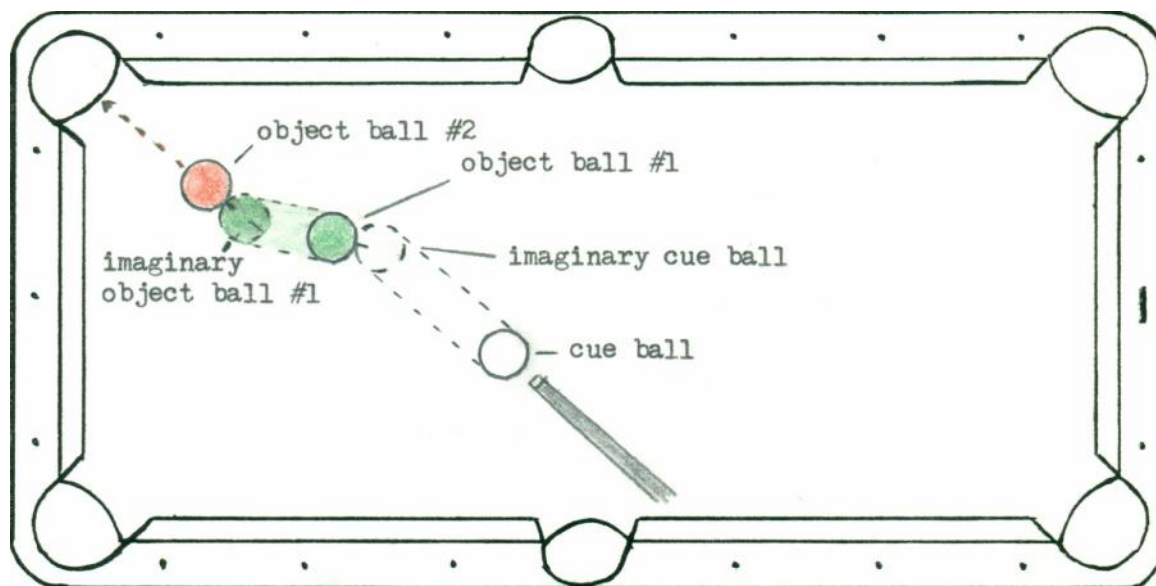


Figure 6: Combination shot that uses its surrounding balls to change the course of the object ball.

Figure 7 shows a variation of the combination shot, where you use non-object balls to redirect the cue ball and then strike the object head on.

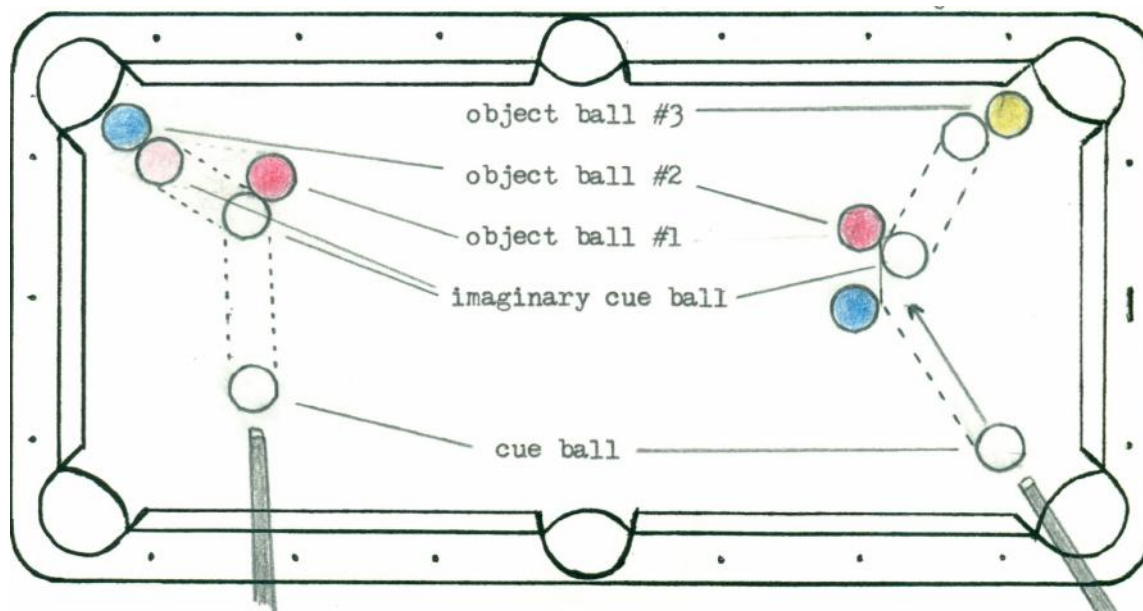


Figure 7: Combination shot that uses a non-object ball to align the cue ball with its target.

Combination shots, like all others featured in our guide, provide options when playing billiards. It is unusual for there to be only one type of shot open, so it comes down to good judgement and preference. As you become more comfortable with a larger selection of shots, you will start to develop strategy, choosing objects based on possible follow up shots and landing the cue ball in favourable positions. Such things are the mark of a pro.

In addition to the shots discussed, experiment with other techniques (i.e. grip, finger support/bridging, pressure and tilt). Having absolute control over your cue will make you a formidable player!



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